# D'var Torah on Parshas Beshalach: Moving Forward Through Fear

## Introduction: Finding Focus in Abundance

We are making our way through Sefer Shemos into Parshas Beshalach. Beshalach contains some of the biggest and most profound moments of Yetzias Mitzrayim itself. We have Kriyas Yam Suf, the splitting of the sea. We have the beginning of the mann, the manna. And we even have Amalek, all in one parsha. It can feel like a lot.

One of the things I try to do in these recordings, in my public writing, and also in my learning in general, is to have a focus, a goal, and an end outcome. Throughout Sefer Shemos, I have been trying to identify what it means to be a Jew, both the good, and also the areas that require teshuvah, growth, and repair.

The Jewish people are not portrayed in the Torah as perfect. We see their struggles, their complaints, their fears. And through understanding these moments, we come to understand ourselves.

## The Power of Sending: Understanding Beshalach

One helpful way to reflect on this perspective can begin with the name of the parsha itself, Beshalach. The Torah opens (Shemos 13:17): " ויהי בשלח פרעה את העם ולא נחם אלקים דרך ארץ פלשתים," And it was when Pharaoh sent out the people, and God did not lead them by way of the land of the Philistines.

Beshalach comes from the root שלח, to send. This is not merely a narrative detail. The act of sending, of creating distance, appears throughout Torah as a powerful concept.

When we look at this word throughout Chumash, and very often throughout Tanach, we find that it carries a sense of separation. Not only because something is being sent away, but because what is being sent is given its own independent space to exist.

That separation allows us to observe something from the outside, without being fully emotionally trapped inside the moment. Think about when you're in the middle of an argument, everything feels overwhelming. But if you can step back, observe from the outside, suddenly clarity emerges.

In our parsha, Paroh sends out Bnei Yisrael. Later in the Torah we have another parsha called Shelach (Bamidbar 13:2), where spies are sent to Eretz Yisrael: "שלח לך אנשים ויתרו את ארץ כנען," Send out for yourself men and let them spy out the land of Canaan. The idea is that something is sent outside of oneself, so that it can act independently. A shaliach, a messenger, does my will, but ideally from a clear and balanced perspective.

The Gemara in Kiddushin (41b) establishes a fundamental principle: "שלוחו של אדם כמותו," A person's agent is like himself. When I send a shaliach, they carry my authority, but they also have the distance to act with clarity.

Sometimes, however, sending can be forceful, emotional, and abrupt. Just get out of here. How sending happens depends very much on the reality and emotional state of the moment.

The Torah describes Paroh's final sending (Shemos 12:31-33): "ויקרא למשה ולאהרן לילה ויאמר קומו צאו מתוך עמי גם אתם גם בני ישראל ולכו עבדו את ה' כדברכם," And he called for Moshe and Aharon at night and said, "Rise up, get out from among my people, both you and the Children of Israel, and go serve Hashem as you have spoken."

This is not a gentle release. This is expulsion. Paroh cannot bear their presence any longer. Rashi comments on the word "קומו," rise up: "מהרו לצאת," Hurry to leave. The sending is desperate, almost panicked.

With that background, and with my broader approach to Sefer Shemos, we can now enter the parsha itself.

## The Erev Rav and the Three-Day Journey

Bnei Yisrael are sent out by Paroh, and importantly, the Erev Rav, the mixed multitude, come along with them. The Torah records (Shemos 12:38): "וגם ערב רב עלה אתם וצאן ובקר מקנה כבד מאד," And also a mixed multitude went up with them, and flocks and herds, very much livestock.

Who were the Erev Rav? Rashi explains that they were Egyptians who converted and joined the Jewish people. But their conversion was incomplete, motivated more by fear of Hashem's power than by genuine spiritual transformation. They would become a source of ongoing challenge throughout the wilderness journey.

At first, the entire expectation is that this is a three-day journey. This connects back to the original request to go serve Hashem for three days in the wilderness. Moshe had said to Paroh multiple times (Shemos 3:18, 5:3, 8:23): "דרך שלשת ימים נלך במדבר," A journey of three days we shall go in the wilderness.

Why three days? On the surface, it seems like a negotiating tactic. But there's something deeper here.

Because Klal Yisrael were leaving a state of deep emotional trauma. They had endured generations of suffering and oppression. The Torah describes the oppression (Shemos 1:13-14): "ויעבדו מצרים את בני ישראל בפרך. וימררו את חייהם בעבדה קשה," And Egypt enslaved the Children of Israel with crushing labor. And they embittered their lives with hard work.

When a person leaves such a reality, sudden freedom can be overwhelming. Psychology teaches us that even when a prisoner is released, even after rehabilitation, the sudden return to

freedom can create anxiety and disorientation. The structure of prison, as oppressive as it is, becomes familiar. Freedom means choice, and choice can be paralyzing.

Soldiers leaving military frameworks often experience something similar. The rigid structure, while limiting, provides certainty. Civilian life requires constant decision-making, and that can feel like chaos.

Freedom itself can be frightening.

The three-day plan allowed for gradual emotional integration into freedom. It was not an abyss of endless possibilities. It was a short, manageable step. A contained journey with a clear destination and timeframe.

## Witnessing the Makkos: The Foundation of Emunah

During the makkos, Klal Yisrael witnessed the destruction of Egyptian deities, the collapse of the natural order, and the absolute mastery of Hashem over every detail of creation, from lice and dust to animals and hail.

The plague of lice was particularly significant. The Torah records (Shemos 8:15): "ויאמרו החרטמים אל פרעה אצבע אלקים הוא," And the magicians said to Pharaoh, "This is the finger of God." The Egyptian sorcerers, who had replicated the first two plagues, could not create lice. Chazal explain (Sanhedrin 67b) that sorcery has no power over something smaller than a barley grain. Life at that microscopic level can only come from Hashem.

From the smallest to the largest, from the kinim that the Egyptian magicians could not replicate, to the barad, hail, that destroyed everything in the field (Shemos 9:25): "ויך הברד בכל ארץ מצרים את כל אשר בשדה," And the hail struck throughout all the land of Egypt everything that was in the field.

And then finally, Paroh sends them out. The Torah describes his breaking point (Shemos 12:32-33): "גם צאנכם גם בקרכם קחו כאשר דברתם ולכו... כי אמרו כלנו מתים," Also your flocks and your herds, take as you have spoken and go... for they said, we are all dead.

"Get out of here. You are too much for me. I cannot handle you anymore."

## Paroh's Pursuit: When Freedom Becomes Real

But then Paroh changes his mind. The Torah tells us (Shemos 14:5): "ויגד למלך מצרים כי ברח העם ויהפך לבב פרעה ועבדיו אל העם," And it was told to the king of Egypt that the people had fled, and the heart of Pharaoh and his servants turned against the people.

Why does the Torah use the word "ברח," fled? They didn't flee; Paroh sent them out! Rashi explains that Paroh realized they weren't coming back after three days. What he thought was temporary was actually permanent. The reality of true freedom hit him, and he couldn't accept it.

And Klal Yisrael themselves begin to realize that they are more free than they have ever been. They are moving forward. Hashem is guiding them with a pillar of cloud by day and fire by night (Shemos 13:21). Moshe is leading them. And then they hear that Paroh is chasing them.

The Torah describes (Shemos 14:9): "וירדפו מצרים אחריהם וישיגו אותם חנים על הים," And Egypt pursued after them and overtook them camping by the sea. All of Pharaoh's horses, his chariots, his horsemen, and his army.

## At the Sea: Four Responses to Crisis

They reach the Yam Suf, with Paroh behind them. The Torah describes their terror (Shemos 14:10): "ופרעה הקריב וישאו בני ישראל את עיניהם והנה מצרים נסע אחריהם וייראו מאד ויצעקו בני ישראל אל ה'," And Pharaoh drew near, and the Children of Israel lifted their eyes and behold, Egypt was traveling after them, and they were very frightened, and the Children of Israel cried out to Hashem.

And we immediately see the natural human reactions appear.

Chazal describe four responses. The Mechilta (Beshalach, Masechta D'Vayehi, Parsha 3) and Shemos Rabbah (21:8) detail these four groups, each representing a different response to overwhelming crisis:

**One group says, let us daven.** Let us cry out to Hashem. This sounds righteous, but it's incomplete. Prayer without action is not enough.

**Another group says, let us return to Egypt.** It is better to live as slaves than to die. The Torah records them saying (Shemos 14:12): "הלא זה הדבר אשר דברנו אליך במצרים לאמר חדל ממנו ונעבדה את מצרים כי טוב לנו עבד את מצרים ממתנו במדבר," Is this not the thing we spoke to you in Egypt saying, leave us alone and we will serve Egypt? For it is better for us to serve Egypt than to die in the wilderness. This is regression, nostalgia for the familiar suffering.

**Another group says, let us fight.** We have our freedom and we are willing to defend it. This is courage, but it's misplaced self-reliance. They cannot defeat Paroh's army on their own.

**And the last group says, let us jump into the sea.** It is better to die in the water than to be murdered by the Egyptians. This is despair, giving up entirely.

Four responses: prayer, regression, fighting, and despair. And remarkably, none of them is correct.

In the end, Hashem responds with direction and with rebuke. The Torah records (Shemos 14:15): "ויאמר ה' אל משה מה תצעק אלי דבר אל בני ישראל ויסעו," And Hashem said to Moshe: Why do you cry out to Me? Speak to the Children of Israel and let them travel.

Rashi explains: "מה תצעק אלי, אין הדבר תלוי אלא בהם," Why do you cry out to Me? The matter does not depend on Me, but on them. Stop complicating reality. I gave you a direction, and you must move.

And what is that direction? "ויסעו," Let them travel. Go into the sea for life, not for death.

The answer is not to pray endlessly, not to retreat, not to fight hopelessly, and not to despair. The answer is to move forward with faith.

## Nachshon's Leap: Faith in Action

And that is what happens. But not immediately. The people stand at the edge, hesitating. Until one man steps forward.

The Gemara in Sotah (37a) records: "אמר רבי מאיר בשעה שעמדו ישראל על הים היו שבטים מנצחים זה עם זה אומר אני יורד תחלה לים וזה אומר אני יורד תחלה לים קפץ שבטו של בנימין וירד לים תחלה... רבי יהודה אומר לא כך היה מעשה אלא זה אומר איני יורד תחלה וזה אומר איני יורד תחלה קפץ נחשון בן עמינדב וירד לים תחלה," Rabbi Meir said: When Israel stood at the sea, the tribes were arguing with each other. This one said "I will go down first" and that one said "I will go down first." The tribe of Binyamin jumped and went down first... Rabbi Yehuda said: It was not like this. Rather, this one said "I am not going down first" and that one said "I am not going down first." Nachshon ben Aminadav jumped and went down into the sea first.

According to Rabbi Yehuda's version, no one wanted to go first. Everyone was afraid. Until Nachshon ben Aminadav, from the tribe of Yehuda, jumped in. And only when the water reached his nose, when he was about to drown, did the sea split.

This is faith. Not the absence of fear, but moving forward despite fear.

The Torah continues (Shemos 14:21-22): "ויט משה את ידו על הים... ויבאו בני ישראל בתוך הים ביבשה והמים להם חמה מימינם ומשמאלם," And Moshe stretched out his hand over the sea... and the Children of Israel came into the midst of the sea on dry land, and the waters were a wall for them on their right and on their left.

## Miracles Within Miracles

Chazal and the mefarshim describe that the miracle was far greater than we might imagine. Shemos Rabbah (21:10) teaches: "לא נעשה הים יבשה בלבד אלא נעשו בו אילנות של פירות," The sea didn't just become dry land, but fruit trees grew in it. The righteous walked through a garden.

There are many layers to this miracle. Was there one path or many paths? The Mechilta describes twelve paths, one for each tribe. Was there a separate channel for each shevet? How did the Erev Rav travel among them?

The mefarshim describe that the paths curved within the sea, so that neither the Egyptians nor the Jews could fully see one another. The walls of water were transparent like glass from the

Jewish side but opaque from the Egyptian side. And finally, Klal Yisrael emerge on the other side.

## Fear Returns: Breaking the Cycle

They look back and see Paroh still pursuing them, and they are afraid yet again.

From our perspective this is difficult to understand. They saw the makkos. They witnessed ten plagues, each one a complete upheaval of nature. They left Egypt. They survived. They were enriched with the wealth of Egypt, as the Torah records (Shemos 12:35-36): " ובני ישראל עשו כדבר משה וישאלו ממצרים כלי כסף וכלי זהב ושמלת... וינצלו את מצרים," And the Children of Israel did as Moshe said and requested from Egypt silver vessels, gold vessels, and garments... and they emptied out Egypt.

They had mesorah, tradition passed down from the Avos. They had Moshe, the greatest prophet. They had Hashem leading them with visible miracles, a pillar of cloud by day and a pillar of fire by night (Shemos 13:21-22). And still, fear returns.

Why?

Hashem says, this is exactly where I need you to be right now. I want to break this mentality of fear. It is time to break the cycle of being terrified of the nations of the world. It is time to learn what yiras Hashem, fear of Hashem, truly is, as opposed to fear of man.

The fear of man is paralyzing. The fear of Hashem is liberating.

## The Bodies on the Shore: Seeing the Future

Hashem closes the sea. The Egyptians drown. Their bodies are cast upon the shore. The Torah records (Shemos 14:30-31): " ויושע ה' ביום ההוא את ישראל מיד מצרים וירא ישראל את מצרים מת על שפת הים. ויראו ישראל את היד הגדלה אשר עשה ה' במצרים וייראו העם את ה' ויאמינו בה' ובמשה עבדו," And Hashem saved Israel on that day from the hand of Egypt, and Israel saw Egypt dead upon the seashore. And Israel saw the great hand that Hashem did against Egypt, and the people feared Hashem and believed in Hashem and in Moshe His servant.

Why is this necessary? Why do the bodies need to wash up on shore?

Because there are two dimensions of emunah here. One is to see that you are saved in the present. The other is to see that your future is also protected.

If I give a poor person five dollars today, that helps today. But it does not yet create security for tomorrow. Tomorrow they will be hungry again. Hashem shows Klal Yisrael that not only are they saved now, but that those who sought to destroy them are being removed from the equation entirely. The Egyptians will never chase them again. Only then can their trust deepen.

Rashi explains on the words "וירא ישראל את מצרים מת": "ראו אותן מושלכים כאבנים," They saw them cast up like stones. The very bodies that represented power, oppression, and terror were now lifeless shells on the beach.

The result? "ויאמינו בה' ובמשה עבדו," And they believed in Hashem and in Moshe His servant.

## The Mann: Daily Training in Emunah

This experience becomes the foundation for the mann.

Just as Hashem showed them at the sea that He would take care of both the present and the future, the mann now becomes a daily training in that same trust. The Torah describes (Shemos 16:4): "הנני ממטיר לכם לחם מן השמים ויצא העם ולקטו דבר יום ביומו למען אנסנו הילך בתורתי אם לא," Behold, I will rain down for you bread from heaven, and the people shall go out and gather each day's portion on its day, in order that I may test them, whether they will follow My teaching or not.

Notice: "למען אנסנו," in order that I may test them. The mann is not just sustenance, it's a test. A daily exercise in trust.

Every day, exactly what was needed fell from heaven. The Torah continues (Shemos 16:16-18): "לקטו ממנו איש לפי אכלו עמר לגלגלת... וימדו בעמר ולא העדיף המרבה והממעיט לא החסיר איש לפי אכלו לקטו," Gather from it, each person according to what he eats, an omer per head... And they measured with an omer, and the one who gathered more had no surplus, and the one who gathered less had no lack; each person according to what he eats, they gathered.

No more and no less, except for Shabbos. A perfect portion for each person's needs.

When people took extra because they lacked emunah for the next day, it rotted. The Torah records (Shemos 16:19-20): "ויאמר משה אלהם איש אל יותר ממנו עד בקר. ולא שמעו אל משה ויותרו אנשים ממנו עד בקר וירם תולעים ויבאש," And Moshe said to them: Let no man leave over from it until morning. But they did not listen to Moshe, and some people left over from it until morning, and it became full of worms and it stank.

The lesson? You cannot hoard trust. You cannot stockpile security. Emunah is a daily practice.

And Chazal teach us in the Gemara (Yoma 75a) that people experienced the mann differently based on their level of righteousness. "צדיקים מוצאים אצל פתח ביתם, בינונים מחזרין ומלקטין, רשעים מרחיקין ומלקטין," The righteous found it at the entrance of their homes, the average people had to walk around and gather it, and the wicked had to travel far to gather it.

Those with stronger emunah found it at their door. Those whose emunah was weaker had to walk further to collect it. Some had to search much more.

This is not just history. It is the existential reality of being a Jew.

## Ma'aminim Bnei Ma'aminim: The Unbreakable Core

We are ma'aminim bnei ma'aminim, believers the children of believers. The Gemara in Shabbos (97a) uses this phrase to describe the Jewish people's essential nature: " ישראל מאמינים בני מאמינים," Israel are believers, children of believers.

Sometimes our emunah is stronger, sometimes it is weaker, but there is always something inside us. As Chassidim used to say, there is a pintele Yid, a Jewish spark inside, that can never be extinguished.

The Tanya (Chapter 18) explains that every Jewish soul has an essential connection to Hashem that cannot be severed, no matter how far a person strays. This connection is what makes teshuvah always possible, always accessible.

All the tests of the midbar, the wilderness, are our tests today. The fear at the sea. The complaints about water at Marah (Shemos 15:23-24). The craving for meat (Shemos 16:3). The thirst at Refidim (Shemos 17:2-3). We are constantly being given opportunities to see where we stand, and how we respond to the realities of our own lives.

## Our Generation: The Same Struggles

Over the last several years, my wife and I often speak about the reality of hatred toward Klal Yisrael, again and again. Paroh pursues even after his defeat. He hardens his heart until his destruction. The Torah describes (Shemos 14:8): " ויחזק ה' את לב פרעה מלך מצרים וירדף אחרי בני ישראל," And Hashem strengthened the heart of Pharaoh king of Egypt, and he pursued after the Children of Israel.

Even after witnessing everything, even after his entire kingdom was destroyed, even after his own son died, Paroh cannot let go. He pursues to his own death.

We look at our own generation and we see enemies to the south, to the north, and to the east, repeatedly choosing destruction and hatred over life and peace. We see this unfolding in our own lifetime.

As I am speaking, it is Erev Shabbos. I do not know what will happen over Shabbos. I try to live with emunah and bitachon. Baruch Hashem, I live in Eretz Yisrael. I have access to Torah. I have a life. And yet people continue to try to harm us and diminish us.

Klal Yisrael endured hundreds of years of real enslavement. Their suffering is beyond what we can truly grasp. The Ramban calculates that they were enslaved for 210 years. Generations born into slavery, knowing nothing else. And still, fear surfaced again and again even after freedom.

Today as well, people are afraid. Not healthy caution, but real terror. And yet, if I truly believe that I am a believer, a descendant of believers, then my daily questions cannot bring me into panic. We have direction. We are guided. We are led forward step by step.

## The Erev Rav Within and Around Us

We also cannot forget the Erev Rav.

Not only the historical Erev Rav who joined us leaving Egypt, but the Erev Rav within us and around us. Those voices that constantly try to shake our trust in Hashem.

"No, we should be more afraid." "No, we are not doing enough." "No, Hashem is not responding properly." "No, we need different strategies."

The voices of doubt, of second-guessing, of fear masquerading as practicality, of criticism masquerading as wisdom. These are the Erev Rav of our generation, whether they come from outside or from within our own hearts.

The Vilna Gaon teaches that the Erev Rav are not just a historical group, but an ongoing spiritual reality. In every generation, there are voices that sound Jewish, that claim to speak for Jewish interests, but that ultimately sow doubt and weaken emunah.

Sometimes the greatest avodah, the greatest spiritual work, is to step back and reflect. To ask: is this voice coming from emunah or from fear? From trust in Hashem or from trust in my own calculations?

## Reflection and Growth

For this Shabbos, I invite us all to ask ourselves:

**On Following Direction:**

- Am I following the instruction I was given, or am I constantly searching for alternatives that feel more logical to me?
- When Hashem says "travel forward," do I move, or do I stand frozen, analyzing every possible outcome?

**On Contentment:**

- Am I content with what I have, with my mann, or am I always demanding more and complaining that it is not enough?
- Do I recognize the daily miracles in my life, or do I only see what I lack?

**On Trust:**

- Am I thirsty even when I am being given water?
- Do I trust that Hashem is providing exactly what I need, exactly when I need it, or do I hoard and worry about tomorrow?

**On Learning from History:**

- Am I learning from the mistakes of Klal Yisrael in the midbar, or am I repeating them?
- Do I see the patterns of complaint, fear, and doubt in my own life?

## Closing Thought: One Foot in Front of the Other

So many themes come together in this parsha. The trauma of leaving slavery and the difficulty of adjusting to freedom. The fear at the sea and the four inadequate responses. The miracle of the splitting and Nachshon's leap of faith. The bodies on the shore, showing us that the threat is truly over. The daily mann, training us to trust one day at a time. The Erev Rav, the voices of doubt that travel with us. The constant tests of faith in the wilderness.

May we merit to learn from the mistakes of Klal Yisrael in the midbar, and not to repeat them. May we place one foot in front of the other, and move forward as we were told to do.

The sea does not split for those who stand still and endlessly analyze. The mann does not fall for those who refuse to gather it with trust. Freedom is not given to those who long for the familiarity of slavery.

We are believers, children of believers. We have the pintele Yid inside us that can never be extinguished. We have direction from Hashem. We are guided by Torah and mesorah. And we are called to walk forward, with emunah and bitachon, one step at a time, into the sea if necessary, trusting that the path will appear.

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Good Shabbos.